Out-of-Stock Substitution Guide

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Marvel CPG is a fictional company created for the University at Buffalo CDA 650 capstone. This document was written by Team 1 for the project's RAG knowledge base. Figures marked data *come from the project dataset; everything else is fictional business content.*

1 Purpose

When a Marvel SKU is out of stock in a store, the shopper either buys another Marvel product, buys a competitor, goes to another store, waits, or does not buy at all. This guide tells field representatives and store staff which Marvel SKU to offer instead, in what order, and when there is no acceptable substitute. A substitute protects today's sale; it does not fix the stock-out. Always also fix the cause (section 8).

2 Substitution rules

Offer a substitute in this order of preference:

1. **Same product, different pack size.** The same formula in a smaller or larger pack (for example Laundry Pods 20ct for Laundry Pods 42ct). This is the closest match for the shopper.
2. **Same product line, different scent or variant.** The same use and pack in another fragrance (for example Power Clean Original 1L for Power Clean Lemon 1L).
3. **Same category and use, different format.** For example HE liquid detergent instead of pods. Say clearly that the format is different.
4. **No acceptable substitute.** Some SKUs have no equivalent in the Marvel range (glass cleaner, rinse aid, stain remover, bleach). Do not force a product that does a different job; restore stock instead.

Always:

- Prefer a substitute that is **in stock in the same store today** and, when there is a choice, an **MSL** SKU.
- Stay **within the same category**. Never offer a product from another category as a substitute.
- **Never suggest combining products** to replace a missing one, and never present bleach as an alternative to a cleaner (see PUB-03).
- Do not transfer claims. A substitute does not inherit the missing product's claims (for example "antibacterial" or "with aloe").
- Show the price difference honestly. The comparisons below use the trade list price and the list price per fl oz or per count from MCPG-01.

3 Quick reference: all 23 SKUs

Out of stock	First choice	Second choice
Marvel Power Clean Lemon 1L	Marvel Power Clean Original 1L	Marvel Power Clean Lavender 750ml
Marvel Power Clean Original 1L	Marvel Power Clean Lemon 1L	Marvel Power Clean Lavender 750ml
Marvel Power Clean Lavender 750ml	Marvel Power Clean Lemon 1L	Marvel Power Clean Original 1L
Marvel Heavy-Duty Degreaser 1L	Marvel Heavy-Duty Degreaser 500ml	Marvel Power Clean Lemon 1L
Marvel Heavy-Duty Degreaser 500ml	Marvel Heavy-Duty Degreaser 1L	-
Marvel Glass & Surface Spray 32oz	Marvel Power Clean Lemon 1L	-
Marvel Bathroom Foam Cleaner 20oz	Marvel Power Clean Original 1L	Marvel Power Clean Lemon 1L
Marvel Multi-Surface Wipes 75ct	Marvel Power Clean Lemon 1L	Marvel Power Clean Original 1L
Marvel Dish Soap Citrus 28oz	Marvel Dish Soap Original 28oz	Marvel Dish Soap Antibacterial 28oz

Out of stock	First choice	Second choice
Marvel Dish Soap Original 28oz	Marvel Dish Soap Citrus 28oz	Marvel Dish Soap Antibacterial 28oz
Marvel Dish Soap Aloe 22oz	Marvel Dish Soap Original 28oz	Marvel Dish Soap Citrus 28oz
Marvel Dishwasher Pods 45ct	Marvel Dishwasher Pods 20ct	-
Marvel Dishwasher Pods 20ct	Marvel Dishwasher Pods 45ct	-
Marvel Dish Rinse Aid 8.45oz	None: restore stock	-
Marvel Dish Soap Antibacterial 28oz	Marvel Dish Soap Original 28oz	Marvel Dish Soap Citrus 28oz
Marvel Laundry Detergent HE 100oz	Marvel Laundry Detergent HE 50oz	Marvel Laundry Pods 42ct
Marvel Laundry Detergent HE 50oz	Marvel Laundry Detergent HE 100oz	Marvel Laundry Pods 20ct
Marvel Laundry Pods 42ct	Marvel Laundry Pods 20ct	Marvel Laundry Detergent HE 100oz
Marvel Laundry Pods 20ct	Marvel Laundry Pods 42ct	Marvel Laundry Detergent HE 50oz
Marvel Fabric Softener Lavender 64oz	Marvel Fabric Softener Fresh 64oz	-
Marvel Fabric Softener Fresh 64oz	Marvel Fabric Softener Lavender 64oz	-
Marvel Stain Remover Spray 22oz	None: restore stock	-
Marvel Bleach Clean White 96oz	None: restore stock	-

4 Surface Cleaners substitutes

4.1 If Marvel Power Clean Lemon 1L (SKU-1001) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Power Clean Original 1L (SKU-1002): list price $4.40 (-2% vs $4.50), $0.130 per fl oz vs $0.133; MSL.
2. **Second choice:** Marvel Power Clean Lavender 750ml (SKU-1003): list price $3.90 (-13% vs $4.50), $0.154 per fl oz vs $0.133; optional (non-MSL; carried by 132 of 221 accounts).

Why: same line, same size, different scent.

4.2 If Marvel Power Clean Original 1L (SKU-1002) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Power Clean Lemon 1L (SKU-1001): list price $4.50 (+2% vs $4.40), $0.133 per fl oz vs $0.130; MSL.
2. **Second choice:** Marvel Power Clean Lavender 750ml (SKU-1003): list price $3.90 (-11% vs $4.40), $0.154 per fl oz vs $0.130; optional (non-MSL; carried by 132 of 221 accounts).

Why: same line, same size, different scent.

4.3 If Marvel Power Clean Lavender 750ml (SKU-1003) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Power Clean Lemon 1L (SKU-1001): list price $4.50 (+15% vs $3.90), $0.133 per fl oz vs $0.154; MSL.
2. **Second choice:** Marvel Power Clean Original 1L (SKU-1002): list price $4.40 (+13% vs $3.90), $0.130 per fl oz vs $0.154; MSL.

Why: same line, different scent, larger pack. The 1 L packs cost the shopper less per fl oz.

4.4 If Marvel Heavy-Duty Degreaser 1L (SKU-1004) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Heavy-Duty Degreaser 500ml (SKU-1005): list price $3.50 (-40% vs $5.80), $0.207 per fl oz vs $0.172; optional (non-MSL; carried by 128 of 221 accounts).
2. **Second choice:** Marvel Power Clean Lemon 1L (SKU-1001): list price $4.50 (-22% vs $5.80), $0.133 per fl oz vs $0.172; MSL.

Why: same formula, smaller pack. Power Clean is an everyday cleaner, not a heavy-duty degreaser: offer it only for light grease and say so.

4.5 If Marvel Heavy-Duty Degreaser 500ml (SKU-1005) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Heavy-Duty Degreaser 1L (SKU-1004): list price $5.80 (+66% vs $3.50), $0.172 per fl oz vs $0.207; MSL.

Why: same formula, larger pack. There is no other heavy-duty degreaser in the range.

4.6 If Marvel Glass & Surface Spray 32oz (SKU-1006) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Power Clean Lemon 1L (SKU-1001): list price $4.50 (+7% vs $4.20), $0.133 per fl oz vs $0.131; MSL.

Why: no glass cleaner alternative in the range. Power Clean cleans sealed surfaces but is not a streak-free glass cleaner. For glass and mirrors, restore stock instead.

4.7 If Marvel Bathroom Foam Cleaner 20oz (SKU-1007) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Power Clean Original 1L (SKU-1002): list price $4.40 (+16% vs $3.80), $0.130 per fl oz vs $0.190; MSL.
2. **Second choice:** Marvel Power Clean Lemon 1L (SKU-1001): list price $4.50 (+18% vs $3.80), $0.133 per fl oz vs $0.190; MSL.

Why: all-purpose cleaner for sealed bathroom tile and sinks. Power Clean does not foam or cling; it is a reasonable stop-gap, not a like-for-like product.

4.8 If Marvel Multi-Surface Wipes 75ct (SKU-1008) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Power Clean Lemon 1L (SKU-1001): list price $4.50 (-12% vs $5.10), different format, so compare doses or loads on the product labels rather than price per unit; MSL.
2. **Second choice:** Marvel Power Clean Original 1L (SKU-1002): list price $4.40 (-14% vs $5.10), different format, so compare doses or loads on the product labels rather than price per unit; MSL.

Why: same use, different format (liquid instead of wipes). A format change: shoppers who want wipes for convenience may not accept it.

5 Dishwashing substitutes

5.1 If Marvel Dish Soap Citrus 28oz (SKU-1009) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Dish Soap Original 28oz (SKU-1010): list price $3.15 (-2% vs $3.20), $0.112 per fl oz vs $0.114; MSL.
2. **Second choice:** Marvel Dish Soap Antibacterial 28oz (SKU-1015): list price $3.40 (+6% vs $3.20), $0.121 per fl oz vs $0.114; MSL.

Why: same line, same size, different scent.

5.2 If Marvel Dish Soap Original 28oz (SKU-1010) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Dish Soap Citrus 28oz (SKU-1009): list price $3.20 (+2% vs $3.15), $0.114 per fl oz vs $0.112; MSL.
2. **Second choice:** Marvel Dish Soap Antibacterial 28oz (SKU-1015): list price $3.40 (+8% vs $3.15), $0.121 per fl oz vs $0.112; MSL.

Why: same line, same size, different scent.

5.3 If Marvel Dish Soap Aloe 22oz (SKU-1011) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Dish Soap Original 28oz (SKU-1010): list price $3.15 (+12% vs $2.80), $0.112 per fl oz vs $0.127; MSL.
2. **Second choice:** Marvel Dish Soap Citrus 28oz (SKU-1009): list price $3.20 (+14% vs $2.80), $0.114 per fl oz vs $0.127; MSL.

Why: same line, larger pack. Do not present the alternatives as containing aloe.

5.4 If Marvel Dishwasher Pods 45ct (SKU-1012) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Dishwasher Pods 20ct (SKU-1013): list price $3.50 (-49% vs $6.80), $0.175 per count vs $0.151; optional (non-MSL; carried by 141 of 221 accounts).

Why: same formula, smaller pack. Two 20-count packs (40 pods) replace one 45-count pack.

5.5 If Marvel Dishwasher Pods 20ct (SKU-1013) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Dishwasher Pods 45ct (SKU-1012): list price $6.80 (+94% vs $3.50), $0.151 per count vs $0.175; MSL.

Why: same formula, larger pack.

5.6 If Marvel Dish Rinse Aid 8.45oz (SKU-1014) is out of stock

No like-for-like substitute (no rinse aid alternative in the range). Restore stock; dishwasher pods do not replace rinse aid.

5.7 If Marvel Dish Soap Antibacterial 28oz (SKU-1015) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Dish Soap Original 28oz (SKU-1010): list price $3.15 (-7% vs $3.40), $0.112 per fl oz vs $0.121; MSL.
2. **Second choice:** Marvel Dish Soap Citrus 28oz (SKU-1009): list price $3.20 (-6% vs $3.40), $0.114 per fl oz vs $0.121; MSL.

Why: same line, same size. The alternatives are not antibacterial: tell the shopper, and never imply the claim.

6 Laundry substitutes

6.1 If Marvel Laundry Detergent HE 100oz (SKU-1016) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Laundry Detergent HE 50oz (SKU-1017): list price $5.30 (-42% vs $9.20), $0.106 per fl oz vs $0.092; MSL.
2. **Second choice:** Marvel Laundry Pods 42ct (SKU-1018): list price $10.50 (+14% vs $9.20), different format, so compare doses or loads on the product labels rather than price per unit; MSL.

Why: same formula, smaller pack; then a format change to pods. Two 50 oz bottles replace one 100 oz bottle.

6.2 If Marvel Laundry Detergent HE 50oz (SKU-1017) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Laundry Detergent HE 100oz (SKU-1016): list price $9.20 (+74% vs $5.30), $0.092 per fl oz vs $0.106; MSL.
2. **Second choice:** Marvel Laundry Pods 20ct (SKU-1019): list price $5.40 (+2% vs $5.30), different format, so compare doses or loads on the product labels rather than price per unit; optional (non-MSL; carried by 124 of 221 accounts).

Why: same formula, larger pack; then a format change to pods.

6.3 If Marvel Laundry Pods 42ct (SKU-1018) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Laundry Pods 20ct (SKU-1019): list price $5.40 (-49% vs $10.50), $0.270 per count vs $0.250; optional (non-MSL; carried by 124 of 221 accounts).
2. **Second choice:** Marvel Laundry Detergent HE 100oz (SKU-1016): list price $9.20 (-12% vs $10.50), different format, so compare doses or loads on the product labels rather than price per unit; MSL.

Why: same formula, smaller pack; then a format change to liquid. Two 20-count packs (40 pods) replace one 42-count pack.

6.4 If Marvel Laundry Pods 20ct (SKU-1019) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Laundry Pods 42ct (SKU-1018): list price $10.50 (+94% vs $5.40), $0.250 per count vs $0.270; MSL.
2. **Second choice:** Marvel Laundry Detergent HE 50oz (SKU-1017): list price $5.30 (-2% vs $5.40), different format, so compare doses or loads on the product labels rather than price per unit; MSL.

Why: same formula, larger pack; then a format change to liquid.

6.5 If Marvel Fabric Softener Lavender 64oz (SKU-1020) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Fabric Softener Fresh 64oz (SKU-1021): list price $5.80 (-2% vs $5.90), $0.091 per fl oz vs $0.092; optional (non-MSL; carried by 139 of 221 accounts).

Why: same line, same size, different fragrance.

6.6 If Marvel Fabric Softener Fresh 64oz (SKU-1021) is out of stock

1. **First choice:** Marvel Fabric Softener Lavender 64oz (SKU-1020): list price $5.90 (+2% vs $5.80), $0.092 per fl oz vs $0.091; MSL.

Why: same line, same size, different fragrance.

6.7 If Marvel Stain Remover Spray 22oz (SKU-1022) is out of stock

No like-for-like substitute (no stain remover alternative in the range). Restore stock. Do not suggest pouring detergent or bleach onto stains as a replacement; follow product labels only.

6.8 If Marvel Bleach Clean White 96oz (SKU-1023) is out of stock

No like-for-like substitute (no bleach alternative in the range). Restore stock. Never suggest another product as a bleach replacement, and never suggest combining products.

7 What to tell the store and the shopper

- Tell the store owner which SKU is missing, which substitute to put forward, and when stock is expected (see section 8).
- Move the substitute next to the empty facing only if the planogram allows it. Do not leave the gap unlabelled.
- For a format or scent change, explain the difference in one sentence. For a pack-size change, explain the price per fl oz or per count.
- If there is no acceptable substitute, say so and give the expected restock date rather than offering an unsuitable product.

8 Fix the cause, not only the shelf

A substitution is a stop-gap. Research on shopper behaviour shows that many shoppers do not substitute at all. In one field study of real stock-outs, 41.5% went to another store and 22% postponed the purchase (PUB-01). In Marvel's own data, on days when a SKU is out of stock, its first-choice substitute sells only 2% to 4% more than usual in the same store *(data)*. So most of the lost sale is not recovered on the shelf.

To fix the cause:

- **Reorder early enough.** Orders arrive a median of 2 days after ordering for Distributors, 3 days for Modern Trade and 5 days for Traditional Trade *(data)*. An order placed when the shelf is already empty means days without stock.
- **Prioritise small accounts.** Tier 3 accounts run out of stock 15.1% of the time against 2.9% for Tier 1 *(data)*. They also tend to order when the shelf holds only about four days of sales (MCPG-04).
- **Watch MSL SKUs first.** A store fails MSL compliance for the day if even one MSL SKU is at zero (MCPG-06, MCPG-08).

9 Data evidence used in this guide

- Product names, brands, categories, pack sizes, MSL flags and list prices come from the product master dim_products.
- The substitute sales check compares the substitute's daily units on days the first SKU was out of stock with its usual daily units in the same store. Pairs checked: Lemon 1L to Original 1L and to Lavender 750ml; Degreaser 1L to 500ml; Laundry Pods 42ct to 20ct; HE 100oz to 50oz; Dishwasher Pods 45ct to 20ct. It is an association in reported data, not a controlled test.
- Lead times and out-of-stock rates: Authorized V3 dataset (dataset hash f5403651d8aa...), reported sell-out

rows 1 Jan 2025 - 31 May 2026; June 2026 held out.

Document control

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Source	PUB-01 (shopper responses to out-of-stocks)

Open points and review notes

- The substitution order is a team proposal for the field team and has not been confirmed by Marvel commercial management.
- Store-level availability of the substitute must be checked in the dashboard (Module 1) before it is recommended.